Real Alcázar de Sevilla

Real Alcázar of Seville - a humanized audio tour

“Allah grant that I may die in Sevilla, and that our graves be opened there on the Day of Resurrection.”

— Al-Mu'tamid, last Abbadid king of Sevilla, writing in exile c. 1091

20 TRACKS / ~108 MINUTES
SEVILLA, SPAIN / UNESCO WORLD HERITAGE SITE

V4 HUMANIZED AUDIO TOUR

About This Tour

WHAT THIS IS

A walking audio tour through the oldest royal palace still in use anywhere in Europe — the Real Alcázar de Sevilla, a fortified palace complex that has been continuously occupied as a royal residence for more than eleven hundred years. The site has been built and rebuilt by every regime that has ruled Sevilla since the year 913: the Umayyad emir Abd al-Rahman III, the Abbadid king Al-Mu'tamid, the Almohad caliphs Abu Yaqub Yusuf and Yaqub al-Mansur, the Castilian conqueror Fernando III, the Gothic king Alfonso X the Wise, the Mudéjar-loving Pedro I, the Habsburg emperor Carlos V, the Bourbon kings, and the current King Felipe VI — who still uses the upper apartments when his family visits Sevilla. UNESCO inscribed the complex in 1987 together with the cathedral and the Archive of the Indies, all three on the same plaza. Most people visit Sevilla once in their lifetime. This tour is built so that one visit feels like enough — and so the memories last.

HOW TO USE IT

Twenty tracks. About 110 minutes of audio. Plan two and a half to three hours total inside — longer if you've added the Cuarto Real Alto upper apartments. The tour starts outside on the Plaza del Triunfo at the Puerta del León entrance, walks you through the Patio del León and the Hall of Justice, lingers at the Almohad Patio del Yeso, brings you into the Patio de la Montería to see Pedro I's spectacular 1364 facade, takes you through the Casa de la Contratación where Spain administered its American empire for two centuries, then deep into Pedro's Mudéjar palace — the Patio de las Doncellas, the Hall of Ambassadors with its 1427 gilded dome, the intimate Patio de las Muñecas, and the underground Almohad cisterns called the Baths of María de Padilla. Then upstairs through the Gothic palace of Alfonso X as remodeled by Carlos V, and finally out into the gardens — seventeen hectares of layered Almohad, Renaissance, Baroque, and English landscape — for the rest of the visit. Each track opens with a Stop and Look note telling you where to stand. Pause anytime. Sit often. This palace rewards slow walking and unhurried gardens.

WHAT'S COVERED

All eleven hundred years of the Alcázar's continuous history. The Puerta del León entrance gate, 12th-century Almohad with a 19th-century tile lion. The Patio del Yeso — one of the few surviving 12th-century Almohad domestic spaces in Spain, designed by Ali al-Gumari from the same workshop tradition as the Giralda. The Hall of Justice built around 1340 by Alfonso XI to commemorate the Battle of Salado. The great Patio de la Montería with Pedro I's spectacular 1364-66 Mudéjar facade — bilingual inscriptions in Castilian Gothic and Arabic Kufic script, the Nasrid motto 'There is no victor but Allah' written by a Christian king. The Casa de la Contratación that founded in 1503 administered all Spanish trade with the Americas for two centuries, including its Sala de Audiencias with Alejo Fernández's Virgin of the Navigators (1531-36) — the first European religious painting to depict the discovery of the New World, with

Columbus, Vespucci, the Pinzón brothers, Carlos V, and indigenous American peoples all sheltered under the Virgin's cloak. The Patio de las Doncellas — its original 14th-century sunken garden buried under marble in 1581-84 and restored after archaeological excavations in 2002-05. The Salón de los Embajadores — Pedro I's throne room, with Diego Ruiz's 1427 gilded media naranja dome of ten-fold lacería knot patterns, where Charles V married Isabel of Portugal just after midnight on March 11, 1526 — an anniversary the city is commemorating this year, in 2026. The Patio de las Muñecas, the Baths of Doña María de Padilla in the 12th-century Almohad cisterns, the Salones de Carlos V in the old Gothic Palace with their Tunis tapestries. The gardens — the Estanque de Mercurio with its 1573 bronze Mercury, the Galería de los Grutescos built by Vermondo Resta 1593-1612, the Pabellón de Carlos V converted 1543-46 from an Almohad qubba. The Game of Thrones locations — the Hall of Ambassadors, the Doncellas, the Baths of María de Padilla, and the gardens — used for the Water Gardens of Dorne in 2014. The Cuarto Real Alto, the working royal apartments still used by King Felipe VI today. UNESCO status, ticket information, and what to see next in Sevilla.

ON SOURCES

Every claim in this tour was verified against primary sources before it was written: the Patronato del Real Alcázar's official documentation at alcazarsevilla.org, the UNESCO World Heritage inscription record of 1987, the archaeological reports of Miguel Ángel Tabales and his University of Sevilla team (Patio de las Doncellas excavations 2002-05), the Atlas de Arquitectura Almohade (work of Antonio Almagro Gorbea and Rafael Manzano Martos), the Archnet/Dumbarton Oaks publications of Antonio Almagro and Luis Ramón-Laca, peer-reviewed work in the academic literature on the Salón de los Embajadores plasterwork, the Cervantes Institute's virtual library, and the Patronato's official ticketing and visitor information at realalcazarsevilla.cliqueo.es. Several common tourist claims were corrected after verification — including the popular but unfounded story that María de Padilla actually bathed in the Almohad cisterns (no historical evidence; she likely never did), the misattribution of the Salón de los Embajadores dome to Pedro I (Diego Ruiz built it in 1427, sixty years after Pedro), and the lazy framing of Pedro I as simply 'cruel' (his Castilian contemporaries called him 'el Justiciero,' the Just; he was a polarizing king and the historians still don't agree).

VOICE

Reverent but grounded. Storytelling-forward. Companion, not commander. The Alcázar is unusual in that it is at once a fortified medieval palace and an active royal residence, a UNESCO World Heritage Site and a working maintenance project. Eleven hundred years of overlapping Islamic and Christian architecture, with every century visible at once — twelfth-century Almohad stucco under fourteenth-century Mudéjar plaster under fifteenth-century gilded wood under sixteenth-century tapestries under eighteenth-century Baroque repairs. The tour respects what each space asks for. It also acknowledges the uncomfortable history embedded in some of the most beautiful objects. The Casa de la Contratación administered slave shipping. The Tunis tapestries celebrate a colonial war. The Virgin of the Navigators sheltered conquistadors and

indigenous victims of those conquistadors under the same cloak. The fact that this palace is glorious does not erase what made parts of it possible. The tour says both things — because most people only visit Sevilla once, and they deserve to take home not just the wonder but the truth.

Tracks

01	Welcome	★	~3.5 min
02	The Oldest Palace Still in Use in Europe		~5.0 min
03	The Lion Gate		~2.9 min
04	The Hall of Justice		~3.1 min
05	The Patio del Yeso — All That's Left of the Almohads	★★	~4.0 min
06	The Hunters' Courtyard and the Facade of 1364	★★	~5.5 min
07	The House of Trade		~3.3 min
08	The Virgin of the Navigators	★★	~5.0 min
09	The King Who Built a Muslim Palace		~4.7 min
10	The Patio de las Doncellas — The Buried Garden	★★	~5.4 min
11	The Hall of Ambassadors	★★	~4.1 min
12	The Night the Emperor Married		~6.2 min
13	The Dolls' Courtyard		~3.3 min
14	The Baths of María de Padilla		~3.1 min
15	The Gothic Palace and the Tapestries of Tunis		~4.0 min
16	The Gardens — A Thousand Years of Water	★★	~4.8 min
17	The Mercury Pond, the Grotesco Gallery, and the Pavilion		~4.4 min
18	Dorne		~4.7 min
19	The King Still Lives Here		~4.9 min
20	What's Next		~5.7 min

TRACK 01 / 20

Welcome

★ ANCHOR

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Stand in the Plaza del Triunfo, with the Real Alcázar's red-ochre walls in front of you and the cathedral at your back. Find the Puerta del León — the Lion Gate — the main visitor entrance. Take a moment before you walk in.*

Welcome back.

If you've just come from the cathedral, you're about to do something extraordinary — you're about to walk from the largest Gothic cathedral on earth into the oldest royal palace still in use anywhere in Europe. Two UNESCO World Heritage sites, on the same plaza, both inscribed in the same year, both shaped by the same thousand years of Andalusian history. You picked the right city.

If this is your first stop in Sevilla — also welcome. The cathedral can wait until later. This building has its own story to tell, and it tells it differently than anything else in Spain.

What you're standing in front of is called the Real Alcázar — the Royal Palace. The word alcázar comes from the Arabic al-qasr, meaning fortified palace or large stone building from which power is projected. There are several alcázares in Spain, but this is the great one. The original. Walls behind those red battlements were first laid down in nine hundred and thirteen, more than eleven hundred years ago. The place has been continuously occupied — first by Muslim rulers, then by Christian kings, now by a constitutional monarchy — every year since. When King Felipe the Sixth and his family visit Sevilla, they still stay in the upper rooms. You can sometimes tell, from the queue, if they're in residence — those days the visitor numbers get tightened.

Now, here's the unusual thing about this palace, and the reason it matters.

Almost every other great medieval building in Europe expresses a single moment in time. Notre-Dame is Gothic. The Doge's Palace in Venice is Venetian Gothic. The Tower of London is Norman. They each crystallized in one period and stayed there. But the Real Alcázar is different. It is a thousand-year palimpsest, with every era layered visibly on top of the last. Twelfth-century Almohad walls. A fourteenth-century Mudéjar palace built by a Christian king using Muslim craftsmen. A thirteenth-century Gothic palace by Alfonso the Wise. A Renaissance dome over a Muslim throne hall. Sixteenth-century apartments where the Holy Roman Emperor got married. Eighteenth-century repairs after the Lisbon earthquake. Nineteenth-century English-style gardens. Twentieth-century restorations that uncovered things hidden for four hundred years.

You're not visiting a building. You're visiting a stack of buildings, each one preserved inside the next.

Here's how we'll walk it. Twenty tracks. About an hour and a half of audio. We'll enter through the Puerta del León, pass through the Patio del León, see the oldest surviving Almohad fragments, then enter the Patio de la Montería where the great Mudéjar facade of Pedro the First is the headline event of any visit. From there we'll go inside Pedro's palace — the Patio de las Doncellas, the Patio de las Muñecas, the gilded dome of the Hall of Ambassadors — then through the upper Gothic palace of Carlos the Fifth, and finally out into the gardens. Plan two and a half to three hours total inside.

A note before we start. The Alcázar is busier than the cathedral. There's a cap of seven hundred and fifty people inside at any one time, and they enforce it. If you booked a timed entry, your slot matters. Have your ticket ready. Then take a breath, walk through that gate, and let the eleven hundred years begin.

TRACK 02 / 20

The Oldest Palace Still in Use in Europe

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *You've just passed through the Puerta del León. You're now in the Patio del León — the Lion Courtyard. A wide rectangular space, gravelled, with three large arches on the far wall. Stop here for a moment before walking on. There's a layered story under your feet.*

You are standing on more than two thousand years of stacked history.

Beneath your feet, archaeologists have found Roman walls. Above the Roman level, Visigothic foundations of a Christian basilica from the sixth or seventh century. Above the Visigothic, the Umayyad fort that the caliph Abd al-Rahman the Third ordered built here in the year nine hundred and thirteen. Above the Umayyad, eleventh-century Abbadid additions when Sevilla was an independent Muslim taifa kingdom under the poet-king Al-Mu'tamid. Above the Abbadid, twelfth-century Almohad reconstruction when Sevilla was the European capital of an empire stretching to Marrakesh. Above the Almohad, thirteenth-century Castilian Christian additions after Fernando the Third took Sevilla in twelve forty-eight. And above all of that, the various royal renovations that brought us to today.

The Spanish state lists the Real Alcázar as a Bien de Interés Cultural — a Heritage Site of Cultural Interest. UNESCO inscribed it in nineteen eighty-seven along with the cathedral and the Archive of the Indies. But the most striking fact is the simplest one. This is the oldest royal palace still in use anywhere in Europe. Versailles is younger. Buckingham Palace is much younger. The Vatican is older as a religious site but the current papal palaces are not. Nothing else has been a working royal residence continuously, in some form, for eleven hundred years.

Let me give you the headline names that built it. They'll come back over and over as we walk.

Abd al-Rahman the Third — the first caliph of al-Andalus, the one who declared Córdoba a caliphate independent of Damascus. He ordered the original fort here in nine hundred and thirteen, on the foundations of a Visigothic basilica that itself had stood on a Roman fortress. Quadrangular, walled, about a hundred meters square, attached to the city walls. Almost nothing of this earliest fort is visible above ground today, but the walls of the Patio de Banderas — the courtyard where you'll exit at the end of this tour — still preserve some of his masonry.

Al-Mu'tamid — the eleventh-century Abbadid king of Sevilla, also one of the great poets of Arabic Spain. He expanded the palace southward and renamed it Al-Muwarak, the Blessed Palace. He built a now-vanished throne hall called Al-Turayya — the Hall of the Pleiades — somewhere very near where we'll stand in the Hall of Ambassadors later. When his Almoravid overlords exiled him to Morocco in ten ninety-one, he wrote, from a small town near Marrakesh, that he wanted to be buried back here in Sevilla. He never returned. He died in exile.

The Almohads — the Berber dynasty that ruled both North Africa and most of Muslim Spain from the mid-twelfth century to the early thirteenth. They made Sevilla their European capital. They built two more palaces inside this Alcázar, demolishing much of what came before. The only Almohad architecture you can still see today is the Patio del Yeso, the Patio del Crucero foundations, the Baños de Doña María de Padilla cisterns, and most of the outer walls.

Then in twelve forty-eight, Fernando the Third — the Castilian king buried just across the plaza in the cathedral's royal chapel, the one we visited yesterday if you came from the cathedral tour — took Sevilla after a seventeen-month siege. He moved into the Alcázar. He died in it four years later. His son Alfonso the Tenth, the Wise, built a Gothic palace inside the complex around twelve fifty-eight, which still survives as the Salones de Carlos the Fifth in the upper rooms.

And then in the thirteen sixties, a Castilian Christian king did something nobody had done in Europe before. He hired Muslim craftsmen from Granada, Toledo, and Sevilla itself to build him, in his own royal compound, a palace in the style of his Muslim allies. We're going to spend most of our visit inside that palace. His name was Pedro the First — Pedro the Cruel to his enemies, Pedro the Just to his friends. We'll get to him.

For now — look at those three large arches on the far wall of this courtyard. They're Almohad. Twelfth century. They opened from the original Almohad palace's outer enclosure into its inner ceremonial space. The two side arches were originally horseshoe arches in the Islamic style. The central, taller one was opened later, in the fifteenth or sixteenth century, to align with the new Mudéjar palace beyond.

Walk slowly toward those arches. We're heading first to a small room on your left — the Hall of Justice — and from there into one of the most extraordinary Almohad survivals in Spain.

TRACK 03 / 20

The Lion Gate

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Turn around for a moment. Look back at the gate you just walked through. Above the arch, on the outside facade, a tile panel shows a crowned lion holding a cross and a banner. That's the lion of the Puerta del León. Now turn back into the Patio del León and look at the walls around you.*

You'll have noticed the gate is striking. Red ochre and orange and tan, crenellated wall above, a tile panel with a crowned lion holding a cross and a banner in one paw and a Latin inscription banner in its mouth — Ad utrumque, meaning ready for either, for either war or peace.

The tile panel is from eighteen ninety-four. Local Sevillan ceramic from the Mensaque factory in Triana, just across the river. The lion as a heraldic device for this gate is medieval, but the actual tilework you see now is barely older than my great-grandparents.

The gate itself is much older. The arch and the walls flanking it on both sides are twelfth-century Almohad construction. When Yaqub al-Mansur and his architects were building the Giralda minaret out of brick a thousand meters from where you stand, the same workshops were building these walls. The crenellations, the construction method, the brick patterns — it's all the same Almohad military architecture.

The gate originally served a different purpose. In Pedro the First's day in the fourteenth century, this entrance was called the Puerta de la Montería — the Hunting Gate — because the hunters and their dogs would gather here in the morning before riding out with the king. The current name, Puerta del León, only stuck in the nineteenth century, when the lion panel was added.

Now, the walls. Look at the brick. The lower courses are heavier, more weathered — that's twelfth-century. The upper courses are repairs and additions from various later periods, including thirteenth-century Castilian work after Fernando the Third moved in. The wall continues around the entire Alcázar complex, enclosing about seventeen hectares — that includes the gardens, which we'll get to. From outside, the Alcázar looks like a fortress dropped into the middle of a city, because that's exactly what it is. A fortified medieval palace, sitting in the middle of modern Sevilla.

A small detail worth knowing. The original ninth-century walls of Abd al-Rahman the Third — the very first fortified construction on this site, from nine thirteen — are mostly gone now, replaced by Almohad and later work. But fragments survive. Some are visible in the Patio de Banderas, where you'll exit the tour. Some are below ground, only seen by archaeologists. The continuity of the site is older than the visible walls.

Now turn back into the Patio del León and start walking forward. On your left, before you reach the three large arches, you'll see an open doorway leading into a small but important room. That's where we're going next. It's where Christian kings dispensed justice in this palace for over five hundred years.

TRACK 04 / 20

The Hall of Justice

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Step into the small square room on the left of the Patio del León — the Sala de la Justicia, the Hall of Justice. It's a compact, beautifully decorated room with a marble fountain in the floor, stucco plasterwork on the walls, and a coffered wooden ceiling above.*

This room was built to commemorate a victory in battle.

The battle was the Battle of Río Salado, fought on the thirtieth of October, thirteen forty, near Tarifa on the southern coast of Spain. King Alfonso the Eleventh of Castile, allied with King Afonso the Fourth of Portugal, defeated a much larger Marinid army that had crossed from Morocco to support the Nasrid emir of Granada. It was the last major Moroccan invasion of the Iberian Peninsula. After Salado, no significant African Muslim army would cross into Spain again. The Reconquista was, from that moment, no longer threatened from the south. It would only end one way.

Alfonso the Eleventh built this room around the year thirteen forty to celebrate that victory. Look up at the ceiling — that's a Mudéjar artesonado, an interlaced wooden lacework called lacería, polychromed and gilded, organized around the geometry of the eight-pointed star. The walls below are covered in plasterwork — yeserías — with intertwined floral motifs, Arabic-style inscriptions in cursive script, and the heraldic shield of the Order of the Band, which Alfonso the Eleventh himself founded in thirteen thirty.

The floor is paved with terracotta tiles, with a small white marble fountain set flush into the center. Water from the fountain flows out through a narrow channel into the next courtyard — the Patio del Yeso. We're heading there in a moment. The fountain and channel are not just decoration. They're a deliberate architectural quotation of Andalusi palace traditions, where running water linked interior rooms to exterior gardens, blurring the line between the two.

For a Christian king's throne room of justice, built to celebrate a Christian victory over a Muslim army, the decoration is entirely Islamic in form and inspiration. This is the central paradox of the Mudéjar style. The conqueror, in his moment of triumph, chose to express that triumph in the visual language of the conquered. There are several theories about why. The simplest is that the Castilian kings genuinely admired Andalusi architecture more than any Christian architecture available to them in the fourteenth century. The cathedrals being built in northern Spain — Burgos, León — would have felt foreign and cold to a king who had grown up in Sevilla, where the local building tradition was thoroughly Islamic.

Pedro the First — Alfonso the Eleventh's son, who built the main Mudéjar palace we'll see in a few minutes — extended this aesthetic to its most lavish form. But it starts here. In this small

room. With this ceiling. Built in the thirteen forties.

Now walk through the doorway on the side of the room. There's a small courtyard just beyond it, with a long pool and triple arches and stuccoed walls. It is one of the oldest surviving fragments of Almohad civil architecture anywhere in the world. And almost no one stops to look at it properly.

TRACK 05 / 20

The Patio del Yeso — All That's Left of the Almohads

★★ HERO

STOP & LOOK
Step out of the Hall of Justice into the Patio del Yeso. A rectangular courtyard with a long reflecting pool down its center. On the southern side, the most striking element: a triple-arched portico, with a wide central arch flanked by smaller multi-lobed arches and sebka latticework above. Pause for as long as you can.

This is, in some ways, the most precious thing in the entire Alcázar.

Almost everything else you'll see today is what came after the Christian conquest of twelve forty-eight. Pedro the First's palace, the Gothic apartments, the Renaissance and Baroque additions — all post-Reconquista. But this courtyard? This is the actual twelfth century. The actual Almohad caliphate. The same workshop tradition, in the same decade, in the same city, that built the Giralda's lower brick shaft and the Torre del Oro down by the river.

The triple-arched portico in front of you was almost certainly designed by Ali al-Gumari — the chief court architect of the Almohad caliph Abu Yaqub Yusuf. The same Ali al-Gumari who, in the eleven seventies, was also working on the Giralda. Look closely at the wide central arch and the smaller flanking arches. Then look up at the sebka pattern — those interlaced diamond lattices above the arches. If you walked the Giralda yesterday and looked at her brickwork from close up, you saw exactly this motif. The Patio del Yeso and the Giralda are the same architectural conversation, taking place inside the same workshop, in the same decade. They are siblings.

The name comes from yeso — Spanish for plaster, gypsum stucco. The Patio of the Plaster. Because the wall decoration is almost entirely worked in carved stucco rather than in stone or tile. There's a deep Islamic philosophical idea behind that material choice. The Quran teaches that everything human is temporary, that only Allah is permanent, and that human creation should therefore express its own fragility. Stucco is fragile. It cracks, it weathers, it falls. By choosing stucco for the walls of the palaces, the Almohads were making, in a sense, a statement of theological humility. Only God endures. Our buildings, no matter how beautiful, are passing.

And yet — this stucco has lasted eight hundred and forty years. It has outlasted the dynasty that made it, the city's Islamic period, the Christian Reconquista, the Reformation, the discovery of the Americas, the Spanish Empire, the Lisbon earthquake of seventeen fifty-five, the Napoleonic occupation, the Spanish Civil War, and twenty-six American presidents. The fragile thing turns out to be more durable than the stone palaces of dynasties long forgotten.

The pool in the center was, in the original Almohad arrangement, the heart of the courtyard. Surrounded probably by sunken garden beds with aromatic plants — mint, jasmine, citrus. Above the gardens, raised walkways. The whole composition aimed to create a paradise garden — what the Quran describes as the gardens of the afterlife, with running water, fragrant plants, and shade.

This courtyard was almost lost. By the late nineteenth century it had been heavily altered, subdivided, partly buried under later additions. The historian Francisco María Tubino rediscovered its Almohad character in the late eighteen hundreds. The Marqués de la Vega Inclán and the architect José Gómez Millán led a major restoration between nineteen eighteen and nineteen twenty. Further work was done later in the twentieth century by Rafael Manzano Martos, one of Spain's great historians of Andalusi architecture. What you see is the result of more than a century of slow recovery.

Stay here for a moment. Listen to the water from the fountain in the Hall of Justice flowing into this pool. The Almohads designed it to sound like this. Eight hundred and forty years later, it still does.

Now walk back out through the Hall of Justice and continue toward the three large arches at the end of the Patio del León. We're heading into the most photographed courtyard in the entire palace — and the most spectacular facade in the entire city of Sevilla.

TRACK 06 / 20

The Hunters' Courtyard and the Facade of 1364

★★ HERO

STOP & LOOK
Walk through the three large arches at the end of the Patio del León. You enter a much larger rectangular courtyard — the Patio de la Montería, the Hunters' Courtyard. Stop in the middle of it. In front of you, the great facade of Pedro the First's palace. To your right, the Casa de la Contratación. To your left, the entrance to the Gothic Palace. The facade of Pedro's palace is the one you came to see.

There. That's the photograph everyone takes.

Take it. Take it again. Take it from a different angle. Then come back to me, because I want to tell you what you're looking at, because what you're looking at is one of the strangest objects in the history of European architecture.

This is the main facade of the palace of Pedro the First of Castile, built between thirteen sixty-four and thirteen sixty-six. The king who built it was Christian. He was a Catholic monarch in the line of Fernando the Third and Alfonso the Tenth — descended from the very kings who had taken Sevilla back from Muslim rule a hundred and sixteen years earlier. He had been crowned in front of Christian altars. He waged wars in the name of Christ. He was, by every formal measure, a Christian king.

And he commissioned a facade that reads, from top to bottom, like a Nasrid Muslim palace.

Let me show you what's actually carved in the stucco above your head. Look up at the upper band, the one running along the top of the central portico. It's a long inscription, partly in Castilian Gothic letters and partly in Arabic Kufic script. The Castilian portion declares — and I'll quote it short — "the very high and very noble and very powerful Don Pedro, by the grace of God King of Castiella and León, commanded these Alcázares and these palaces". So far, so Christian. A king named Pedro, by the grace of the Christian God, claiming credit.

But the Arabic Kufic inscription, repeated four times in each direction, says something else. It says wa-l■ gh■liba ill■ All■h. "There is no victor but Allah." That phrase wasn't Pedro's invention. It was the official motto of the Nasrid dynasty of Granada — the last Muslim kingdom in Spain, the one whose Alhambra palace was being decorated in exactly the same decades, in exactly the same style, by exactly the same workshops. The Nasrid sultan Muhammad the Fifth — Pedro's close ally and friend — repeats that phrase, in identical Kufic script, all over the Alhambra.

So Pedro, a Catholic king, in his own royal palace, in the heart of his own kingdom, in his moment of architectural triumph, chose to inscribe on his palace facade the motto of a Muslim dynasty crediting all victory to Allah.

This wasn't done by accident. Pedro and Muhammad the Fifth were genuine allies, more than once. They came to each other's military aid in their respective civil wars. When Pedro decided to build a new palace in thirteen sixty-four, Muhammad sent him his best craftsmen — Granadan stucco workers, tile setters, carpenters who had just finished work on the Court of the Lions in the Alhambra. They were joined by Mudéjar craftsmen from Toledo and from Sevilla itself, who had been working in this style for the local Castilian aristocracy for over a century. Together, they built this facade.

Look at the details now. The horseshoe arches. The sebka latticework — those interlaced diamond motifs above the arches, same as the Patio del Yeso, same as the Giralda. The blind polylobed arches alternating with the openings. The wooden eave on top, carved into muqarnas — the stalactite-like wooden honeycomb that's a signature of Islamic architecture. The blue and white Kufic tile band. The proportions, three-three-three, exactly mirroring the upper galleries of the Comares Palace in the Alhambra.

There is a great deal of ink that has been spilled trying to explain why Pedro did this. The cleanest answer is the most personal one. Pedro grew up in this city. The buildings he loved most were Andalusi. The aesthetics he wanted around him were Andalusi. He had Muslim and Jewish advisors at his court. He signed mutual defense treaties with the Nasrid emir. The accusation of his Christian rivals — that he was too friendly with Muslims and Jews — is one of the reasons his enemies called him Pedro the Cruel. To them, his cosmopolitan tastes were treason. To him, this facade was simply what beauty looked like.

He died for it, in a way. In thirteen sixty-nine, three years after this palace was finished, Pedro was murdered by his half-brother Enrique de Trastámara at Montiel — a death that ended the original Castilian Borgoña dynasty and started the Trastámara line that would lead, eventually, to Isabel the Catholic and her grandson Carlos the Fifth. Pedro is buried in the cathedral's royal chapel just across the plaza, in the crypt below the floor of the Capilla Real. The half-brother who killed him replaced him on the throne. But the palace Pedro built has outlasted them all.

Stand here and look at this facade for as long as you want. It's the heart of the Mudéjar style in all of Spain, and arguably the most consequential thing Pedro left behind. Then we'll explore the building it leads to.

But before we go inside Pedro's palace, there's another wing of the Alcázar we should see — on your right, the doorway leads into rooms that, for two hundred years, ran the entire Spanish empire.

TRACK 07 / 20

The House of Trade

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Walk to the right side of the Patio de la Montería. You'll find a doorway leading to the Cuarto del Almirante — the Admiral's Hall — and the rooms that made up the Casa de la Contratación. Step inside.*

For over two centuries, every gold doubloon, every silver bar, every chili pepper, every cacao bean, every potato, every tomato, every coca leaf, every African enslaved person, every Spanish missionary, every shipment of any kind moving between Spain and the Americas was registered, taxed, blessed, or licensed in these rooms.

The Casa de la Contratación — the House of Trade — was founded by Queen Isabel the Catholic on the twentieth of January, fifteen oh three. Eleven years after Columbus's first voyage. Spain, by that point, had realized that the trickle of returning ships was about to become a flood, and that flood needed regulation. So Isabel set up a single royal institution to handle it. Every ship sailing for the Indies needed a license from the Casa. Every cargo coming back was inspected, taxed, and recorded. The royal fifth — the quinto real, the twenty percent due to the crown on all bullion from the Americas — was collected here. Navigators were trained and licensed here. Maps were drawn, kept secret, updated, and kept secret again, in these rooms.

The Casa lived in the Alcázar from fifteen oh three until seventeen seventeen — two hundred and fourteen years. When Felipe the Fifth eventually moved it to Cádiz in seventeen seventeen, after the Guadalquivir had silted too much for big trade ships, it took its archives with it. Those archives — millions of pages — are now in the Archive of the Indies, the third UNESCO building of this trio, just outside on the Plaza del Triunfo, twenty meters from where you're standing.

But this is where it operated. In these rooms. With these wooden ceilings.

Two things are particularly worth seeing here. The first is the room itself — the Cuarto del Almirante, the Admiral's Hall. It has a Renaissance artesonado wooden ceiling from the sixteenth century, geometric Mudéjar-inspired patterns in coffered wood, gilded. The walls now display a collection of nineteenth and early twentieth-century paintings depicting events in Sevillan history — the Catholic Monarchs receiving Columbus, scenes from the discovery, allegorical figures of the four kingdoms of Spain. They're later works, added to dress the room as a museum, but the ceiling above them is original.

The second thing — and this is the masterpiece of the entire wing — is in the next room. The Sala de Audiencias. The Audience Hall. Step through.

A continuous marble bench runs around the entire perimeter of the room. That's where the officials of the Casa de la Contratación sat — administrators, cosmographers, pilots — in council to decide cargoes and routes. The ceiling above is sixteenth-century Renaissance, with carved coffers. The walls are hung with tapestries showing the heraldic shields of the various admirals and navigators who sailed for Spain.

And at the head of the room, above the altar — because this room also functioned as the chapel of the Casa de la Contratación — is the most extraordinary painting in the Real Alcázar. We're going to spend an entire track with it next.

TRACK 08 / 20

The Virgin of the Navigators

★★ HERO

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *You're in the Sala de Audiencias. Walk to the altar at the far end. Above the altar, the central panel of a triptych retablo. A serene Virgin in a white gown and blue mantle, looking down, sheltering a crowd of figures beneath her open cloak. Below her, a row of ships. Stop in front of it.*

This painting is the first time the discovery of the Americas was depicted in European religious art.

The first. Let me say that again, because most visitors walk past this painting without registering it. Before this painting, no European religious image had depicted the New World. The act of evangelization, the encounter with indigenous American peoples, the ships of the Atlantic crossing — none of it had ever been put into the iconographic vocabulary of Christian art. This painting, made between fifteen thirty-one and fifteen thirty-six by a Sevillan painter of German origin named Alejo Fernández, was the first attempt to do so.

It's called La Virgen de los Navegantes — the Virgin of the Navigators — or sometimes La Virgen del Buen Aire, the Virgin of Fair Winds, or La Virgen de los Mareantes, the Virgin of the Seafarers. Any of those names will lead you to the same painting.

Now let me show you what's actually in it.

The Virgin Mary stands at the center, on a cloud, robed in white with a deep blue mantle that opens out from her shoulders to form a kind of tent above the figures below her. This is the Madonna of Mercy iconography — a medieval European tradition in which the Virgin shelters her devotees beneath her cloak. The new thing here, the radical thing, is who Mary is sheltering.

On her right, beneath one side of the cloak — look closely — a group of European figures kneeling in prayer. Tradition identifies them as Christopher Columbus in golden robes nearest the Virgin, then Amerigo Vespucci, then the Pinzón brothers in their red cloaks, then probably Vicente Yáñez Pinzón, possibly Juan de la Cosa. The men who sailed.

On her left, beneath the other side of the cloak, a group of indigenous American figures. Bare-chested, dark-skinned, also kneeling. The first images of indigenous Americans in a major Spanish religious altarpiece. The painter Alejo Fernández, who never crossed the Atlantic, painted them based on the descriptions and sketches that had been arriving in Sevilla through the Casa de la Contratación for forty years.

Slightly behind the Pinzón brothers, almost as a continuation of the European devotional group, you can sometimes see a figure with imperial features that's been identified as either Fernando the Catholic or — more commonly — the Emperor Carlos the Fifth himself. The painting was

made during his reign and would have hung in his chapel.

Below the Virgin, on the lower register, the ships. Seven distinct types of sixteenth-century Spanish vessel. Caravels, naos, galleons. The full inventory of the early Atlantic fleet. The painter wasn't a naval architect, but his details are remarkably precise — you can identify each ship type by the configuration of its rigging.

The retablo around the central painting was almost entirely lost in the nineteenth century and reconstructed during a restoration in the nineteen sixties. The side panels show Saint Sebastian, Saint James, Saint Elmo — patron of sailors — and Saint John the Evangelist.

Now — here's the difficult thing about this painting, the thing you should know.

It is, theologically, an image of the Virgin Mary blessing the Spanish project in the Americas. It places Columbus and the indigenous peoples alike under her protection. It implies that the encounter between Europe and the Americas was a moment of unification under Christ, supervised by the mother of God.

What it doesn't show — what the painter couldn't show, because the empire was still building its myth about itself in fifteen thirty-six — is what was actually happening in the Americas at the moment the painting was being completed. The population collapse of indigenous peoples from disease, war, and forced labor. The encomienda system. The first African enslaved people being shipped across the Atlantic. The destruction of Aztec and Inca political structures. The transformation of vast cultures into colonized populations.

The painting is beautiful. It is also propaganda — propaganda made before the propagandists fully knew what they were celebrating. The Virgin of the Navigators shelters everyone under her cloak. The actual empire being administered from these rooms did not. I think it's worth standing in front of this painting for a minute and holding both things in your head. The wonder of an art form expanding to depict a new continent. And the suffering that the institution which commissioned it caused.

When you're ready, walk back out into the Patio de la Montería. We're going to go inside Pedro's palace now. But first — let's talk about Pedro himself. Because nothing else about this building makes sense until you understand him.

TRACK 09 / 20

The King Who Built a Muslim Palace

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *You're back in the Patio de la Montería, in front of the great facade. Find a spot where you can see the facade and stand still. Read it again with what I'm about to tell you in mind.*

The king who built this was thirty years old when construction started.

His name was Pedro the First. He was born in Burgos in thirteen thirty-four to King Alfonso the Eleventh — the same Alfonso who built the Hall of Justice — and Queen María of Portugal. He was crowned in thirteen fifty at age sixteen. He reigned for nineteen years. He was murdered at age thirty-four. By the end of his short reign he had become one of the most polarizing figures in medieval Spanish history.

To his enemies — and he had many — he was Pedro el Cruel. Pedro the Cruel. They accused him of executing nobles without trial, of murdering his Aragonese cousins, of assassinating his own half-brothers, of carrying on a public affair with María de Padilla while his wife Blanche of Bourbon languished in royal imprisonment. They wrote chronicles painting him as a despot, a Moor-lover, a Jew-lover, a heretic. His brother Enrique would eventually kill him at Montiel in thirteen sixty-nine and seize the throne. The chronicles written after Enrique's victory shaped Pedro's reputation for centuries.

To his supporters — and he had those too — he was Pedro el Justiciero. Pedro the Just. They argued that what looked like cruelty to the nobility was actually equal justice applied without regard to class. That he protected commoners, Jews, and Muslims against an aristocratic faction that wanted special privileges. That the murders he committed were largely defensive — in a civil war that his enemies had started — and that the chronicles attacking him were written by the victors. The historian Pero López de Ayala, who wrote the harshest contemporary account of Pedro's reign, was himself a political defector who switched sides and ended up serving Pedro's killer. His chronicle is a primary source, and it is also a hostile witness.

Modern historians don't agree. Some emphasize his violence. Others emphasize the systemic violence of all fourteenth-century European kingship and argue that Pedro stands out only because he lost. The closer you get to his actual decisions, the more complicated he becomes.

What is not in dispute is his cultural orientation.

Pedro had Muslim soldiers in his personal guard. He had Jewish financial advisors, including the famous treasurer Samuel ha-Levi, for whom he allowed the construction of a synagogue in Toledo that today is one of the finest medieval synagogues in Spain. He signed mutual defense treaties with Muhammad the Fifth of Granada that were genuinely military alliances against

shared enemies — not just diplomatic gestures. When Muhammad the Fifth was temporarily overthrown in Granada in thirteen fifty-nine, Pedro sheltered him in Sevilla. When Pedro was overthrown by his half-brother in thirteen sixty-six, Muhammad sent troops to help restore him. The two kings depended on each other.

In thirteen sixty-four, after returning to power, Pedro commissioned this palace. He hired the same Granadan craftsmen who had just finished the Court of the Lions in the Alhambra. They worked alongside Toledan Mudéjar masters and local Sevillan artisans. The work took two years. It was inaugurated in thirteen sixty-six.

Three years later, on the twenty-third of March, thirteen sixty-nine, Pedro was lured to a meeting at Montiel, in central Castile, by his half-brother Enrique de Trastámara. Enrique killed Pedro personally, by some accounts with his own hands. Pedro's body was buried first in a small chapel in Montiel, then moved later — at his own daughter Constanza's request — to the cathedral of Seville's royal chapel, where his bones lie today in the crypt below the Capilla Real, fifty meters from where we stood yesterday.

Now look back at his palace facade.

This building is not a museum of a past Spain. It is the personal taste of a specific king. Pedro chose every motif on this wall. He chose the inscription. He chose the materials. He chose to write, on his own palace, that there is no victor but Allah — which is either an extraordinary act of religious tolerance for a Christian monarch, or an extraordinary act of cultural appropriation, or an extraordinary act of theological humility, or all three at once. The man who built this was thirty-four years old when he died, and this facade is what he left.

Now — let's walk through the doorway and see what he built behind it.

TRACK 10 / 20

The Patio de las Doncellas — The Buried Garden

★★ HERO

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Walk through the central doorway of the facade. You pass through a short vestibule and emerge into a long rectangular courtyard with a reflecting pool down its center, surrounded on all four sides by arcaded galleries with multi-lobed arches resting on slender marble columns. Stop near the edge of the pool. This is the Patio de las Doncellas — the Courtyard of the Maidens.*

For four hundred and twenty years, this entire central space looked completely different from what you're seeing right now.

You are standing in front of the most famous courtyard in Sevilla. The one that ends up on every postcard, in every guidebook, in every Game of Thrones promotional still. But what you see today — the long reflecting pool, the sunken garden, the recessed marble pavement around it — is, paradoxically, both very old and very new. It dates from the original construction of the courtyard in the thirteen sixties. It also dates from a restoration completed in two thousand and five.

Between fifteen eighty-one and fifteen eighty-four — during the reign of Felipe the Second — the original Mudéjar pool and sunken garden you're looking at were buried. They were covered over with a white and black marble pavement and a single ornamental fountain placed in the center. The reason was fashion. The Renaissance had arrived. The Italian style, with its taste for flat parterres of marble and ornamental fountains, had reached the Spanish court. The Habsburg administrators of the palace decided the medieval Mudéjar pool was old-fashioned. They paved over it.

For the next four hundred and twenty years, every visitor who came here — from Felipe the Second's grandchildren in the sixteen hundreds to Felipe the Fifth in the seventeen thirties, from the romantic travelers of the eighteen hundreds to the early Lonely Planet readers of the nineteen eighties — saw a Renaissance pavement with a small fountain in the middle. The courtyard was beautiful, but it was not the courtyard Pedro the First had built.

Then in two thousand and two, an archaeological team led by Miguel Ángel Tabales of the University of Sevilla — working with the Patronato del Real Alcázar — began excavating beneath the marble. They were testing a theory that something older might survive underneath. What they found, by two thousand and five, exceeded everyone's hopes. The original fourteenth-century sunken garden, with its long T-shaped pool and brick borders, had been preserved almost intact under the Renaissance fill. The Habsburg pavers had not destroyed it. They had merely buried it.

So in two thousand and four and five, the cathedral chapter of restorers and archaeologists undertook one of the most consequential restoration decisions in the history of the Alcázar. They

removed the marble. They restored the original Mudéjar pool. They replanted the sunken garden with the kinds of aromatic plants — myrtle, orange, jasmine — that fourteenth-century records suggest were originally there. They lowered the central garden by about forty centimeters, exactly as it had been in Pedro's day.

What you're standing in front of is, therefore, two things at once. It is, on one hand, the courtyard as Pedro the First, Muhammad the Fifth's craftsmen, and the people who attended Pedro's court actually saw it in thirteen sixty-six. And on the other, it is a twenty-first century scholarly restoration of that original. The galleries around you — the arches, the columns, the stucco above — those are the genuine fourteenth-century construction. The wooden carved ceilings of the upper galleries are mostly sixteenth-century additions made when the Catholic Monarchs and the Habsburgs adapted this upper floor for their winter quarters. The lower garden and pool are the restored original.

Now look at the arches around you. Twelve on the longer sides — seven on one side, five on the other, with elaborately lobed and interlaced openings. The columns are marble, slender, twin-paired in places, single elsewhere. Above the arches, sebka latticework. Above the sebka, an inscription band in Arabic Kufic script — the same "wa-l■ gh■liba ill■ All■h", there is no victor but Allah, that runs across the facade outside. Above the inscription, polychrome tile panels.

Look at the columns more carefully. Almost every one of them is older than the palace. They were reused — what the Spanish call expolios — from Roman buildings, Visigothic churches, or earlier Almohad and Abbadid structures. The Patio de las Doncellas, like the Mezquita of Córdoba, is built on top of two thousand years of architectural memory. Some of these columns may have been quarried by Romans in the first century. They have stood in three different religions of building since then.

The name — Patio de las Doncellas, Courtyard of the Maidens — comes from a medieval legend. According to the legend, the Muslim emir of Sevilla, before the Christian conquest, demanded a tribute of one hundred maidens every year from the surrounding Christian villages. The story is almost certainly invented — there's no historical evidence for any such tribute — but the name stuck.

The maidens did not exist. The courtyard does. It is, in my view, the most beautiful single space in the city of Sevilla. Spend as much time here as the visitor flow allows. Then walk through the doorway at the far end of the courtyard. Behind it is the room that, more than any other, was the center of political power in fourteenth-century Castile.

TRACK 11 / 20

The Hall of Ambassadors

★★ HERO

STOP & LOOK
Walk through the doorway at the far end of the Patio de las Doncellas. You enter a square room with triple horseshoe arches on three of its four walls, walls covered in tile and plaster, and — above you — a gilded wooden dome that fills the entire ceiling. This is the Salón de los Embajadores, the Hall of Ambassadors. Look up.

This was Pedro the First's throne room. And, almost certainly, it is the most spectacular single room in Spain.

The dome above you was carved and gilded by a master named Diego Ruiz in fourteen twenty-seven — sixty years after Pedro built the room beneath it. It replaced an earlier wooden dome that Pedro had originally installed, which had deteriorated. Diego Ruiz's dome is the one you see today. The Spanish call its shape a media naranja — half an orange — and the room itself is sometimes called the Sala de la Media Naranja, the Hall of the Half Orange, for that reason.

It is, technically, a sixteen-sided polygonal dome interlaced with carved gilded wooden patterns called lacería — ten-fold knot patterns, the most complex in the woodcarver's repertoire. There are only four other domes in the world that use this specific ten-fold knot construction. All four are in Spain.

The dome is sixteen meters high. The walls below it are covered with what is, by mass, the densest concentration of medieval Andalusi decoration anywhere outside the Alhambra. Tile dadoes — alicatados — at the lower level, two meters tall, made of cut interlocking tile pieces in geometric patterns. Above the tile, carved stucco yeserías covering every square centimeter — vegetal patterns, geometric panels, inscriptions in Arabic Kufic and cursive script, Castilian coats of arms in stucco. Wooden balconies — the mirador galleries above the doors — were added at the end of the sixteenth century to allow the Habsburg royal family to watch ceremonies from above.

The room is square. It opens, through triple horseshoe arches supported by paired marble columns, into three different antechambers on its north, west, and east sides. The fourth side — the south, the original qibla wall, the side that would have faced Mecca in the earlier Abbadid hall called Al-Turayya that may have stood on this exact spot — was kept solid by Pedro's architects. The orientation of the room was changed in the thirteen sixties. Whatever Muslim throne hall preceded this one faced east toward Mecca. Pedro's hall opens north, toward the Patio de las Doncellas. The change was deliberate. The new room belonged to a Christian king.

But the room is named for a function it acquired later — not Pedro's throne room, but the ambassadors' reception hall. From the late fourteenth century onward, when Castilian and later Spanish monarchs received foreign delegations in Sevilla, they did so here. The ambassadors from the Holy Roman Empire, from England, from the Italian states, from the Aztec emperor's heirs after the conquest of Mexico — all stood under this dome.

Look at the gothic frieze just below the dome. The painted wooden panels on it are portraits of fifty-six Spanish kings, from the Visigothic ruler Chindasvinto in the seventh century to King Felipe the Third in the early sixteen hundreds. The cycle was painted by Diego de Esquivel between fifteen ninety-nine and sixteen hundred. Each king is shown seated, crowned, holding a sword in one hand and a globe in the other. Below each portrait, the king's coat of arms. Below the coat of arms, the dates of his reign. Pedro the First — the builder of this room — appears on the south wall, painted with the rest. He sits among the kings as one of them, neither glorified nor erased. Just present.

Now — one historical moment that happened in this exact room. It changed Spain.

Just after midnight on the morning of March eleventh, fifteen twenty-six, a wedding took place under this dome. The wedding of an emperor and his cousin. We're going to spend the next track entirely on that night, because it was one of the most consequential weddings in European history and you're standing exactly where it happened.

TRACK 12 / 20

The Night the Emperor Married

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *You're still in the Hall of Ambassadors. Stay here for this track. Look at the room. Try to picture it lit by candles, draped in tapestries, smelling of beeswax, with twenty or thirty people standing in absolute silence just after midnight, five hundred years ago this year.*

Five hundred years ago this year.

That's the anniversary Sevilla is marking right now, in twenty twenty-six. It's the reason the city has put up commemorative banners along the Avenida de la Constitución and along the river. It's the reason there's a special exhibition at the Espacio Santa Clara from late March. It's why every guidebook for Sevilla in twenty twenty-six has a section on Carlos and Isabel.

Five hundred years ago, on the night of March tenth into March eleventh, fifteen twenty-six, just after midnight, in this room — under this exact dome — Charles the Fifth, Holy Roman Emperor, King of Spain, ruler of an empire on which the sun never set, married his first cousin Isabel of Portugal in a quiet ceremony attended by a small handful of people.

He was twenty-six years old. She was twenty-three. They had never met until that afternoon.

The story of how they ended up here is part state strategy, part personal accident, part Lent, part funeral. Let me tell it.

By fifteen twenty-six, Charles the Fifth ruled an empire that included Spain, the Holy Roman Empire of central Europe, the Netherlands, most of Italy, and the rapidly expanding territories of the Spanish Americas. He was the most powerful Christian ruler in the world. But he had a domestic problem. He had been born in Flanders and educated in French. The Castilian nobility resented him as a foreign monarch. The Cortes — the Spanish parliament — had pressed him repeatedly to marry a Spanish woman, to anchor himself in the peninsula. He resisted for years. Then, in fifteen twenty-five, he agreed. The chosen bride was his first cousin Isabel — daughter of Isabel of Aragon and King Manuel the First of Portugal. She was, in other words, the granddaughter of Fernando and Isabel the Catholic, just like Charles himself. Two of the four grandparents of Charles the Fifth and Isabel of Portugal were the same two people.

A papal dispensation was required for the marriage, because they were so closely related. The Vatican granted it.

Isabel left Lisbon in February fifteen twenty-six. She entered Sevilla through the Puerta de la Macarena on the third of March, accompanied by an enormous Portuguese retinue and a dowry of nine hundred thousand gold doblas — one of the largest dowries in European history. The city had erected seven triumphal arches along her route, each dedicated to one of the cardinal

virtues she was expected to bring to the new emperor: Prudence at the Macarena gate, Fortitude near Santa Marina, Clemency near San Marcos, Peace at Santa Catalina, Justice near San Isidoro, Faith at the Salvador, and finally Glory at the cathedral steps.

She arrived at the cathedral, prayed in front of the great altarpiece — the same retablo of Pyeter Dancart that we saw together yesterday — and then was escorted across the Plaza del Triunfo to the Alcázar. There she waited. Charles was still on the road from Madrid.

He arrived seven days later, on the night of the tenth of March. Late. By candlelight. He came directly to the Alcázar. He met his cousin Isabel for the first time in his life, in these very rooms.

By all surviving accounts — letters from courtiers, dispatches from ambassadors, the emperor's own later memoir — there was an immediate emotional spark between them. The biographer Pedro Mexía wrote that Charles, upon seeing Isabel, did not want to wait the planned day or two for the formal ceremony to take place at the cathedral. He insisted on marrying her that same night.

Several practical reasons reinforced his impatience. Lent had begun. Holy Week was approaching. Catholic canon law restricted the public celebration of weddings during Lent. The emperor's beloved older sister Isabel of Habsburg, Queen of Denmark, had died only weeks earlier in Germany — news that had reached Sevilla only a few days before. The court was technically in mourning. And the cardinal who would officiate, Cardinal Salviati, the papal legate, was already in Sevilla and available.

So they were married, by Cardinal Salviati, in this room, just after midnight. The ceremony was attended by perhaps fifteen or twenty people. The future Felipe the Second was conceived within weeks. The public wedding Mass — the misa de velaciones — was held the next morning across the plaza at the cathedral, before the great altarpiece, in front of the assembled nobility of Spain.

What happened afterward, between Charles and Isabel, was unusual for a sixteenth-century royal marriage. They fell genuinely in love. The next six months — what the chroniclers called the imperial honeymoon — were spent traveling through Andalusia, visiting Granada where Charles ordered a Renaissance palace built next to the Alhambra, and returning here to the Alcázar before continuing north. Their surviving correspondence is one of the great love letters of the sixteenth century. When Isabel died in childbirth twelve years later, in fifteen thirty-nine, Charles wore black for the rest of his life. He never remarried.

This is the room where it happened. The dome above you was watching. The ten-fold lacería knot patterns above your head were already a hundred years old. They watched a Castilian Christian king named Charles, descended from the Catholic Monarchs who had ended Muslim rule in Spain, get married in a room covered in Arabic inscriptions praising Allah, built by a king named Pedro who had once allied with Muslim Granada.

History is layered everywhere in this building. But in this room, on this night, the layering was particularly thick.

Stay another moment. Then walk back out into the Patio de las Doncellas and take the small doorway on your right. We're heading to a much more intimate space — Pedro's private quarters.

TRACK 13 / 20

The Dolls' Courtyard

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Step into the Patio de las Muñecas — the Courtyard of the Dolls. A much smaller courtyard than the Doncellas, two stories, surrounded by intricate stucco-and-tile decoration, with a small marble fountain in the center.*

This was the private part of the palace.

If the Patio de las Doncellas was the ceremonial heart — where the king received dignitaries, where ambassadors waited, where the public life of the court happened — then the Patio de las Muñecas was the family heart. Smaller, more intimate, away from the front. The harem, the family quarters, the rooms where Pedro lived when he wasn't being king.

The name — Courtyard of the Dolls — comes from two tiny doll-like faces carved into the stucco at the springing of two of the arches. They're easy to miss. Look up at the spandrels — the spaces between the arches and the wall above — and on two of them, in the corners, you'll see two small carved faces about the size of a coin. Some art historians think they're craftsmen's marks. Others think they're a kind of medieval graffiti — a private joke by the stucco workers signing their work in plain sight. Either way, they've given the courtyard its informal name for as long as anyone can remember.

The courtyard's architecture is, like the Patio de las Doncellas, fourteenth century below and sixteenth century above. The ground floor — the elaborate horseshoe and polylobed arches you see at eye level, the carved stucco between them, the geometric tilework on the walls — is original Pedro the First, thirteen sixty-five. The upper galleries with their balconies and the painted ceilings above them were added in the late sixteenth century by Felipe the Second's renovations.

This is also where the queen lived. Maria de Padilla — Pedro the First's mistress, his great romantic love, the woman whom Pedro reportedly married in secret in thirteen sixty-one even though he was technically still married to Blanche of Bourbon — almost certainly held her court in these rooms. She had been Pedro's companion since they were both teenagers. They had four children together, all of whom Pedro would attempt, after her death in thirteen sixty-one, to legitimize as his royal heirs. Their daughter Constanza of Castile would later marry John of Gaunt, son of King Edward the Third of England, and become the matriarch of an entire English royal lineage. Her descendants, four generations later, included Henry the Seventh of England, and through him, every English monarch since.

So this small courtyard — this private corner of a Mudéjar palace in Andalusia — is the architectural setting of the youth of a woman whose great-great-granddaughter was the mother

of Henry the Eighth. The English Tudor dynasty has roots in this courtyard.

Look at the walls again, knowing that. The stucco around you is the same stucco that Maria de Padilla saw, every morning, when she went out to fetch water from the small fountain. The columns are the same columns. The tile patterns are the same patterns. The space is unchanged in six hundred and fifty years.

When you're ready, walk back through the Patio de las Doncellas and then look for a small staircase going down — or, alternatively, find the doorway leading to the underground baths. We're going below ground next.

TRACK 14 / 20

The Baths of María de Padilla

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Find the entrance to the Baños de Doña María de Padilla. It's an underground space — you'll descend a short staircase. A long, low, vaulted chamber stretches in front of you, with a pool of dark, perfectly still water reflecting the arched ceiling overhead. The temperature drops noticeably as you enter.*

This is one of the strangest spaces in the whole palace.

The vaults around you are twelfth century. Almohad. They were not built as baths. They were built as cisterns — underground reservoirs for storing rainwater for the entire upper palace complex. The Almohads of the late twelve hundreds, who built so much of the Alcázar's underlying infrastructure, understood that Sevilla is hot and that summer water supply was a constant problem. They dug these vaults below the original Patio del Crucero — the Crossing Courtyard — to catch and store the winter rain.

The vaults functioned as cisterns for two hundred years, then continued to function for at least a century after the Castilian conquest. Sometime in the late fourteenth or fifteenth century, after they had outlived their original purpose, the local tradition began to call them the baths of Maria de Padilla. The legend held that Pedro the First's mistress had used these underground pools as a private bathing place, escaping the summer heat above. There is no historical evidence that she ever did. The chronicles of Pedro's court don't mention it. The architecture isn't really suited for bathing — there's no drainage of the right kind, no obvious changing area, no warm pool. But the legend persisted, and the name stuck.

Today, the standing water in the central channel is partly the residual function of the cistern — still slowly catching seepage from above — and partly the deliberate retention of water for aesthetic effect by modern conservators. The reflection of the arches in the still surface is one of the most photographed views in the Alcázar. The light enters from the sides, the water is dark, the temperature is fifteen degrees cooler than the outside.

The vaults are also famous for another reason. In two thousand and fourteen, the HBO television series Game of Thrones used this space — and the gardens above — as the kingdom of Dorne, home of the Martell family. We'll talk more about that in a few tracks. For now: the scene where the Sand Snakes meet in secret to plot revenge for Oberyn Martell's death? Filmed right here, right where you're standing.

Look at the vaults above you. The brick coursing is identical, in technique and dimension, to the brick of the Giralda's lower shaft, the brick of the Patio del Yeso arcade, the brick of the Torre del Oro by the river. The Almohad workshops were prodigious — and consistent. The same hands

that built this storage cistern also built the tower that you climbed yesterday.

When you're ready, climb back to the upper level and head to the Salón del Techo de Felipe Segundo — the Hall with Philip the Second's Ceiling. From there we'll move into the older Gothic Palace, where the emperor Carlos the Fifth held his Habsburg court above the medieval Mudéjar palace below.

TRACK 15 / 20

The Gothic Palace and the Tapestries of Tunis

OBJECT

STOP & LOOK
Find the staircase at the southeast corner of the Patio de las Doncellas and climb up to the Salones de Carlos V — the Halls of Charles the Fifth, which are actually the much older Gothic palace of Alfonso the Tenth, remodeled for the Renaissance court. You'll pass through the Salón del Techo de Carlos V — easily recognized by the wooden coffered ceiling with the Habsburg double eagle — and into the Salón de Tapices, a vaulted hall hung with enormous tapestries.

You've just walked uphill into a much older building.

This is Alfonso the Tenth's Gothic palace, built between twelve fifty-four and twelve sixty — about a century before Pedro the First built his Mudéjar masterpiece downstairs. Alfonso, Pedro's great-grandfather, was the king who took Sevilla's intellectual and cultural heritage and turned it into a coherent royal project — codifying the Castilian language, compiling the Cantigas de Santa María, sponsoring the translations of Arabic philosophy into Latin that would change European thought. His Gothic palace was the original royal residence inside the Alcázar after the conquest.

The building was badly damaged by the Lisbon earthquake of November first, seventeen fifty-five — the same earthquake that destroyed half of Lisbon and was felt as far away as Finland. The earthquake hit Sevilla too. Walls cracked, vaults shifted, parts of the upper palace had to be rebuilt. The architect Sebastián Van der Borcht — a Belgian engineer working in Sevilla, the same man who would later create the great gilded reja for the cathedral's royal chapel — was hired in seventeen fifty-five to repair the damage. He gave the Gothic palace its current Baroque facade facing the Patio del Crucero. Many of the original Alfonsine details were lost in that reconstruction.

What survives — and what you're walking through — is therefore a building that is partly thirteenth-century Gothic, partly sixteenth-century Habsburg renovation, partly eighteenth-century Baroque repair. The room called the Salón del Techo de Carlos V — Charles the Fifth's Ceiling Room — gets its name from its coffered wooden ceiling, gilded, polychromed, with the Habsburg double-headed eagle in the center, the Pillars of Hercules with the imperial motto Plus Ultra carved into the corners. The ceiling was installed in the sixteenth century during Charles's renovations after his fifteen twenty-six wedding.

Plus Ultra means "Further Beyond." It was Charles the Fifth's personal device — a reference to the Atlantic crossings, to the lands beyond the Pillars of Hercules at the Strait of Gibraltar, to the empire he had inherited. Before Charles, the Roman saying had been Non Plus Ultra — Nothing Further Beyond — referring to the limits of the known classical world. Charles dropped the "non". He claimed the further beyond as Spanish territory.

Now walk into the Salón de Tapices — the Hall of the Tapestries.

Six enormous tapestries hang on these walls. They depict scenes from Charles the Fifth's Tunis campaign of fifteen thirty-five — his military expedition against the Ottoman corsair Barbarossa, who had seized the city of Tunis from a vassal of Charles. Charles's fleet attacked, captured Tunis, freed Christian captives, and restored the vassal king. It was one of the great propaganda victories of his reign.

The tapestries you see were woven in the seventeen thirties — about two hundred years after the actual campaign. They are not the originals. The originals were woven in Brussels in the fifteen forties by Willem de Pannemaker, based on cartoons painted by the Dutch artist Jan Cornelisz Vermeyen, who had actually accompanied Charles on the campaign. The originals are still owned by the Spanish crown and kept in storage. These are eighteenth-century replicas, woven in the Royal Tapestry Factory of Madrid, hanging here in their place.

What you see, then, is a Habsburg propaganda cycle, in tapestry form, from the twelve sixties Gothic palace, retold in the seventeen thirties, depicting the fifteen thirties campaigns of an emperor who got married in this very palace in fifteen twenty-six.

Five centuries layered on each other, in one hall. That's the Alcázar in a nutshell.

When you've taken them in, find the doorway leading back out and down. We're heading into the gardens. They are vast. They are layered. And they're going to take the rest of your visit.

TRACK 16 / 20

The Gardens — A Thousand Years of Water

★★ HERO

STOP & LOOK
You've come out of the palaces into the open. The gardens stretch out in front of you — terraces, fountains, parterres of myrtle, citrus and palm trees, distant hedges, water channels. Take a deep breath. Feel the temperature drop. Listen for water.

You just stepped from medieval Spain into a thousand years of garden history.

The gardens of the Real Alcázar cover something close to seventeen hectares. They are home to over twenty thousand plants belonging to roughly one hundred and eighty-seven different species, many of them planted in continuous cultivation since the medieval period. Orange trees descended from twelfth-century Almohad plantings. Myrtle hedges. Cypresses brought from Persia along the trade routes a thousand years ago. Citrus, jasmine, oleander, magnolia, palm. Several of the trees in this garden are over four centuries old — older than the United States, older than the Royal Society, older than the telescope.

But the gardens are not a single project. They are, like the palaces above them, a layered accumulation of separate gardens built over centuries.

The oldest layer — the deepest — is the Almohad concept of the paradise garden. Twelfth century. The Quran describes paradise as a garden with running water, four rivers, shade trees, fragrant plants, and pavilions. The Almohad caliphs of Sevilla, like the contemporary Almohad caliphs of Marrakesh, built their palace gardens to evoke this image. Sunken parterres, geometric quadrants divided by water channels, raised walkways between them. The cool of running water in summer. The smell of orange blossom and jasmine in spring. The gardens were not for crops. They were for meditation. They were for reflecting the architecture of paradise on earth.

When the Castilian Christians took Sevilla in twelve forty-eight, they kept the Almohad gardens. They did not understand them as theology — Christians have different ideas about paradise — but they recognized them as beautiful, and they preserved them. Most of the original Almohad water infrastructure remained in use for centuries.

The next layer was Renaissance. After Charles the Fifth's wedding in fifteen twenty-six, the gardens were extensively renovated to suit Italian Renaissance taste. The Estanque de Mercurio — the Pond of Mercury — was added in the sixteenth century. The bronze statue of Mercury rising from its central fountain was cast by Diego de Pesquera in fifteen seventy-three. To the south of the Mercury pond, a long retaining wall was constructed, decorated with grotesque-style painted scenes — the Galería de los Grutescos, the Grotesco Gallery — which we'll see in a moment. The Italian taste for parterres, perspective views, and ornamental fountains was layered

onto the older Andalusi structure.

The Pabellón de Carlos Quinto — the Pavilion of Charles the Fifth — was converted between fifteen forty-three and fifteen forty-six from an earlier Almohad qubba pavilion into a small Renaissance summer house. Charles the Fifth used it as a personal retreat. It's covered inside and out in sixteenth-century tilework, and it's one of the oldest standing buildings in the garden.

Later still came the Baroque additions of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. New fountains. New parterres. New paths.

And finally, in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the so-called English Garden was added — an Anglo-Romantic landscape of looser plantings, winding paths, picturesque ruins. The Jardín de los Poetas, the Jardín del Príncipe, the Jardín de las Damas, the Jardín del Laberinto — each was created or remodeled in this final wave, when the gardens of the Alcázar were given their current park-like extent.

So when you walk these gardens, you are walking through four distinct conceptions of what a royal garden should be, stacked on top of each other. The Almohad paradise. The Italian Renaissance perspective. The Baroque theatrical garden. The English Romantic park. All four coexist in the same seventeen hectares.

One more thing before you start walking. Listen.

The defining sound of the gardens of the Alcázar — the thing the Almohads understood about gardens in this climate eight hundred years ago — is the sound of running water. Almost every garden has at least one fountain, channel, or pool. Many have multiple. The water comes partly from rainwater collected in cisterns like the ones under the Patio del Crucero, partly from the medieval aqueducts that fed water into the Alcázar from natural springs north of the city, partly from modern municipal supply now. But the sound is the same. Sit on a bench. Close your eyes. Listen. That is the sound of a paradise garden in the late twelfth century. It is still the sound today.

Spend as much time here as you can spare. We'll point you to specific highlights in the next track. But the gardens reward unhurried walking more than any other part of the Alcázar.

TRACK 17 / 20

The Mercury Pond, the Grotesco Gallery, and the Pavilion

OBJECT

STOP & LOOK
Walk to the Estanque de Mercurio — the Pond of Mercury, the large rectangular pool with the bronze statue of Mercury in its center. From there look up to the south. A long arcaded wall stretches along the upper terrace, painted with strange figures and mythological scenes. That's the Galería de los Grutescos.

The Mercury Pond is the central organizing element of the upper garden.

Look at it carefully. The pool is rectangular, framed by a balustrade. In the center, on a raised stone pedestal, a small bronze statue of Mercury — messenger of the gods, patron of merchants and travelers — stands on one foot, his caduceus in his hand, his winged sandals lifting him into the air. The figure was cast in fifteen seventy-three by Diego de Pesquera, working from designs that have been attributed to Bartolomé Morel — the same Bartolomé Morel who, only five years earlier, had cast the Giraldillo on top of the Giralda. The two bronzes are siblings.

The pool itself, in its current rectangular form, was created during the same Renaissance renovations of the late sixteenth century. But the spot was already a Muslim water source — under the pool's eastern edge there are remains of medieval Islamic cisterns that were incorporated into the new design. The pool was, and is, a working hydraulic feature. Water from springs north of the city is still channeled to it, and from it flows out in stone channels to feed the lower gardens and parterres.

Above the pool, the Galería de los Grutescos.

This long, arcaded wall was built between fifteen ninety-three and sixteen twelve, by the architect Vermondo Resta — an Italian working at the Spanish court — on top of what had originally been part of the Almohad outer defensive wall. The decision was to keep the wall but to dress it in Italian Renaissance Mannerist clothing. The decorations are painted directly on the wall — frescoes in the "grotesque" style — strange hybrid creatures, half-human, half-animal, painted in vivid colors, mythological scenes, classical figures. The word "grotesque" comes from the Italian grotta — cave — because this kind of Roman wall painting was first rediscovered, by Renaissance Italians, in underground Roman ruins that they took to be caves.

The Grutesco Gallery has been heavily restored over the centuries — most recently in the nineteen nineties. What you see is faithful to the original sixteenth-century composition, though the actual pigment is partly modern reconstruction.

If you walk to the south end of the gallery, climb the stairs at its eastern end — the stairs are themselves built into the Almohad wall — you'll come out on top of the gallery, on a raised walk. From there you have a panoramic view across the lower gardens. It's one of the best views in the Alcázar, and most visitors miss it.

Now find the Pabellón de Carlos Quinto.

It's south of the Mercury pond, set in a small geometric parterre. Square in plan, brick on the outside, completely tiled inside, with four semi-circular arches supported by marble columns on each face. A small dome on top.

This pavilion was originally an Almohad qubba — a small square garden pavilion in the Islamic tradition, dating from the twelfth century — that survived from the original Muslim gardens of the Alcázar. Between fifteen forty-three and fifteen forty-six, on the personal commission of Charles the Fifth, it was converted into a Renaissance summer house in the Mudéjar style. The conversion was supervised by Juan Hernández. The interior was completely tiled with sixteenth-century azulejos in geometric and floral patterns. Benches were added around the inside walls. Charles used it as a place to dine outdoors in summer, sheltered from the sun, with water flowing past the open arches.

It is the oldest standing building in the gardens. It has been continuously in use for almost five hundred years.

And — small bonus — it's where, in twenty fourteen, the actors playing Myrcella Baratheon and Trystane Martell filmed their kissing scene in Game of Thrones season five. Sitting on the bench inside, kissing, with the camera tracking through one of the side arches.

Which brings us, naturally, to our next track. Because there's an entire layer of why people come to the Alcázar that I have not yet addressed, and it would be unfair to pretend it doesn't matter.

Let's talk about Dorne.

TRACK 18 / 20

Dorne

CONTEXT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Stay in the gardens for this track. Wander if you like, or find a bench. Anywhere with a view of palm trees and a fountain will do. The whole conversation works wherever you stop.*

A meaningful fraction of the people walking through these gardens right now did not come for the Almohads.

They came because of a television show. Game of Thrones. Specifically, the Dorne storyline of season five — the part with the Sand Snakes, with Prince Doran in his wheelchair, with Jaime Lannister and Bronn arriving by sea to rescue Princess Myrcella from her arranged marriage to Trystane Martell. The kingdom of Dorne, the southernmost realm of fictional Westeros, was filmed almost entirely here. In this palace. In these gardens. In the year twenty fourteen.

I'm not going to apologize for this. The show is one of the most-watched television productions in history, the Alcázar is one of the most beautiful palaces on earth, and the moment HBO's location scouts walked through here in twenty thirteen they recognized exactly what they were looking at. The Mudéjar architecture of southern Spain is, in the geographic imagination of the show, the architectural equivalent of the Dornish desert — hot, southern, vaguely Mediterranean, half-Moorish, half-Christian. Dan Weiss, the show's co-creator, has said publicly that the Alcázar was as if designed for them.

Four specific places inside the Alcázar were used. Let me name them.

The Salón de los Embajadores — the room you stood in with me an hour ago, looking up at the ten-fold knot lacería dome — was used as Prince Doran Martell's throne room. The scene where Jaime Lannister, brought before the wheelchair-bound prince after his failed rescue attempt, negotiates the return of Princess Myrcella to King's Landing. The opening camera shot of that scene, framed from the floor looking up past Jaime toward the gilded dome above, used the actual dome — Diego Ruiz's fourteen twenty-seven masterpiece — as its backdrop.

The Patio de las Doncellas was used as the central courtyard of the Martell palace — the so-called Water Gardens of Sunspear. Several of the scenes of Trystane and Myrcella walking together were filmed in the galleries around the long reflecting pool.

The Baños de Doña María de Padilla — the underground vaults where we just were — were used as the meeting place of Ellaria Sand and the Sand Snakes, where they conspire to abduct Myrcella in revenge for Oberyn Martell's death at the Mountain's hands.

And the gardens — most especially the area around the Estanque de Mercurio — were used as the open palace gardens of Sunspear, where Prince Doran sits in his wheelchair and contemplates the politics of the south. The Pabellón de Carlos Quinto, as I mentioned, was used for the kiss scene between Myrcella and Trystane.

In the show's plot, these locations belong to the Martell family — a fictional dynasty descended from Rhoynar refugees who arrived in Westeros from across the sea, blending Eastern and Western traditions. House Martell's words are "Unbowed, Unbent, Unbroken." Their sigil is a red sun pierced by a golden spear. They are, in George R. R. Martin's geography of his fantasy world, the most Mediterranean-inflected house in Westeros. The Alcázar was chosen because Mediterranean-inflected, ornate, and openly fusion of Christian and Muslim architectural traditions is exactly what the Alcázar is.

There is nothing dishonest about this layer of the Alcázar's modern fame. The show brought hundreds of thousands of new visitors to Sevilla. It brought the gardens, in particular, to audiences who would never otherwise have heard of Almohad water engineering or Mudéjar tile decoration. Many of those visitors then discovered the actual history of the place — Pedro the First, Muhammad the Fifth, Charles and Isabel, the buried fourteenth-century garden — and went away knowing more than they came to know.

The actors are gone. The cameras are long packed up. The gilded dome is back to doing what it has done for almost six hundred years, which is being a dome. But if you came for Dorne — which, if you are one of the meaningful fraction, you did — please take in the rest of what's around you too. The fictional kingdom that drew you here is gone in seven years. The real palace it was filmed in has been here for eleven hundred. There is no contradiction. They both belong to you now.

Now — let's go look at one more part of the Alcázar that almost no day visitor sees. The current royal apartments.

TRACK 19 / 20

The King Still Lives Here

OBJECT

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *If you have a ticket to the Cuarto Real Alto — the Upper Royal Apartments — this is your moment. You'll go up a staircase to the upper floor of Pedro the First's palace. If you don't have the ticket, no problem — listen anyway, because what's described here tells you something important about why this palace is different from every other historic palace you've visited.*

Above the rooms we just walked through, on the upper floor of Pedro the First's palace, there are about fifteen rooms that are still — today, in twenty twenty-six — used as a residence by the King of Spain.

When King Felipe the Sixth and his family come to Sevilla for an official visit, they stay here. When Queen Letizia and the princesses join him, they stay here. The current visitor cap of seven hundred and fifty people inside the Alcázar is partly because the royal family occasionally uses the upper rooms, and those rooms are above the rest of the palace, and they need quiet and security.

This is unusual. Almost every other royal palace you might visit in Europe — Versailles, Hampton Court, the Hofburg, the Royal Palace of Madrid — is a museum. A historical monument. The current heads of state, if there still are any, live elsewhere. Versailles has been a museum since the French Revolution. Hampton Court has been a museum since the eighteenth century. The Hofburg is mostly a museum, though some Austrian state functions still happen there.

The Real Alcázar is a working royal palace. Not a museum. The lower floor is opened to the public during the day, the gardens are opened, the Casa de la Contratación rooms are opened — but the upper floor, the Cuarto Real Alto, is the King of Spain's house. The lawnmower still cuts the grass. The maintenance staff still cleans the rooms every week, whether or not the family is in residence.

If you have the optional ticket, here's what you'll see. Fifteen rooms furnished as a working royal apartment. Sixteenth and seventeenth-century coffered wooden ceilings — many of them adaptations made for the Catholic Monarchs in the fourteen seventies, when Isabel the Catholic adapted the upper floor of Pedro's Mudéjar palace as her winter residence. The future Felipe the Second's father, Charles the Fifth, was born in Ghent but spent much of his Spanish residency in these rooms. The future Felipe the Second himself, conceived shortly after his parents' wedding in the Hall of Ambassadors directly below you, was born nine months later in Valladolid, but his earliest childhood was here.

Among the rooms: the audience room, the Catholic Monarchs' bedroom, the oratory of the Catholic Kings — a tiny private chapel with sixteenth-century azulejos showing the Annunciation

by Niculoso Pisano, the Italian ceramic master who introduced majolica tile-painting techniques to Spain. The chapel is small enough for one person to kneel in. Isabel the Catholic did, regularly.

There is a salón of Felipe the Second, decorated with Habsburg portraits. There is a billiards room added in the nineteenth century. There are rooms used by Queen Isabel the Second in the eighteen hundreds, by the Bourbon kings of the early twentieth century, by Felipe the Sixth and Letizia today.

If you've booked the Cuarto Real Alto, photography is not allowed inside. Visits are guided, in fixed time slots, in the morning only. You need to arrive at the Puerta del León sixty minutes before your slot, store your bags, pass security, and present yourself at the Cuarto Real Alto entrance fifteen minutes before your slot. If you don't have it — most visitors don't — you'll skip this section. But you should know it's there. Above you. Lived in. Occupied.

Because here is the thing the Alcázar wants you to remember.

Every other room in this palace — the Patio del Yeso, the Hall of Justice, the Patio de las Doncellas, the Salón de Embajadores, the gardens — exists as part of a continuous, unbroken line of royal use that started in nine thirteen and has not stopped. Eleven hundred and thirteen years. The same building, used as a royal residence, by every kind of regime — Umayyad caliphate, Abbadid taifa kingdom, Almohad caliphate, Castilian medieval monarchy, Habsburg empire, Bourbon dynasty, Republic, Civil War, restored constitutional monarchy. The building has outlasted all of them. It is still doing its original job.

This is the oldest royal palace still in use in Europe. We say that in the literature, and on the audio guides, and on the tickets. But the phrase loses some of its weight unless you stop and let it land. Felipe the Sixth, in twenty twenty-six, sleeps in the same building where Abd al-Rahman the Third's governors slept in nine fourteen. Eleven hundred years of continuous occupation, in the same enclosure.

Now — let's go to the closing track. Walk back to the gardens and find a quiet spot. We're almost done.

TRACK 20 / 20

What's Next

CLOSE

> **STOP & LOOK**
> *Find a bench in the gardens. Anywhere quiet. We'll exit through the Patio de Banderas after this track — the small plaza on the south side of the complex — but first, one last sit-down.*

You've just spent the better part of three hours inside eleven hundred years.

Take a breath. Look up. The sky over the Alcázar is the same sky that arched over Abd al-Rahman the Third's first fort in nine hundred and thirteen. The same orange trees you can smell from here have been planted in continuous succession since the Almohads. The same fountains have been running, with interruptions, since the twelfth century. Sevilla has many extraordinary places, but this one is uncommonly continuous. Almost nothing else in Europe has been the same building, doing the same job, for this long.

Some practical things before we part.

Your ticket — if you bought general admission for fifteen euros fifty cents online — covered everything you saw today except the Cuarto Real Alto, which is an extra five euros fifty for the upper apartments. Reduced tickets are eight euros for visitors over sixty-five, students up to twenty-five from the European Union, and certain disability categories with documentation. Children under sixteen are free. There's a small free admission window — the last hour on Mondays — but those tickets must be booked online in advance and book out fast.

The Alcázar opens at nine-thirty every day. From October first to March thirty-first it closes at five p.m., with evacuation by five forty-five. From April first to September thirtieth it stays open until seven p.m., with evacuation by seven forty-five. It's closed on January first, January sixth — the feast of the Epiphany — Good Friday, and December twenty-fifth.

You'll exit through the Patio de Banderas, the small triangular plaza on the south side of the complex. As you walk out, look at the walls. Some of the masonry there is the oldest still standing in the Alcázar — fragments of Abd al-Rahman the Third's original ninth-century fort. The very beginning of the building. You walk out, in a sense, through the deepest layer.

Three quick recommendations for what's next.

The first is just across the Plaza del Triunfo. The Archive of the Indies — the Archivo General de Indias — is the third building in the nineteen eighty-seven UNESCO inscription that includes the Cathedral and the Alcázar. It's housed in the Casa Lonja de Mercaderes, the old merchants' exchange, built at the end of the sixteenth century. The archive holds the original documentary record of the Spanish empire in the Americas — millions of pages of correspondence, contracts,

maps, accounts. The original letters of Christopher Columbus. Of Hernán Cortés. Of Francisco Pizarro. Selections rotate through the public exhibition halls. Admission is free. If you can spare an hour, it's a different kind of weight than the palace — paper, ink, official seals — but the same history.

The second is the Barrio de Santa Cruz, the old Jewish quarter, immediately to the east of the Alcázar. It's where Jewish Sevillans lived for centuries before the expulsion of fourteen ninety-two. The streets are narrow, winding, white-walled, lined with orange trees and tile-fronted houses. The Plaza de los Refinadores, the Plaza Santa Cruz, the Calle Mateos Gago. You can walk it in an hour. You won't get lost — Santa Cruz is small, bounded by the Alcázar walls on one side and the avenue on the other — but you may want to.

The third is the Real Alcázar's own gardens at sunset. If you bought a morning ticket, you may be able to come back for the last admission hour in the evening, depending on your day. Or come back tomorrow. The light on the Patio de las Doncellas in late afternoon, on the Mercury Pond near closing, on the orange trees — the Alcázar is different in that light. Many guidebooks recommend it. They're right.

A note about the city beyond. If you came to Sevilla on this trip and you have time for one more thing tomorrow, the local consensus among Sevillan historians is the Casa de Pilatos. It's a sixteenth-century Andalusian palace built by the Marquesses of Tarifa, who modeled it loosely on what they had seen on a pilgrimage to Jerusalem. The result is one of the most beautiful private noble palaces in Spain, smaller than the Alcázar but in the same architectural family — Mudéjar courtyards, gardens, tilework. About ten minutes' walk from where you're sitting.

And if you stay a third day, the Roman ruins of Itálica, fifteen minutes north of the city by bus, are worth the trip. They're the birthplace of the emperors Trajan and Hadrian, and the amphitheater there is the same amphitheater that served as the Dragonpit in the later seasons of Game of Thrones.

Sevilla is bigger than the Cathedral and the Alcázar. Most travelers visit Sevilla once. Make this trip count. Walk slowly. Sit often. Drink water. Have an orange.

This is the end of the tour. Thank you for walking through eleven hundred years with me. The Alcázar will still be here when you leave. It will still be here when your great-grandchildren come. And the orange trees in front of you have, every spring, on cue, for a thousand years, started flowering at exactly this moment in the year. They'll do it again next spring. They have not missed yet.

Walk out through the Patio de Banderas when you're ready. Sevilla is waiting.